

Above: Iron Man suit torso concept art (Phil Saunders)

Right: Iron Man pants concept art (Phil Saunders)

An early attempt to conceptualize how Iron Man would get in and out of his armor led Saunders and his fellow illustrators to an armor breakdown that included a minimum number of segments, including the torso and pant leggings shown here.

SAUNDERS: "We wanted to make it as quick as possible for Stark to get in and out of the suit, so instead of having boots and leggings be four separate pieces, we wanted everything from the waist down to basically be a single, organic piece. It would expand open enough that he could slide his legs into it like a really long ski boot and then it would seal up tight upon him. You would start from the bottom and work your way up so that the suit would in fact give you enough strength to put the next piece on, because this whole thing is supposed to weigh half a ton. Then you'd have the bottom torso, something a little like a tank top to be the understructure of the torso, then a clamshell that was the ribcage, and arm pieces you would put on last. Then, of course, the helmet. While we never went with this, the panel breakup was still useful when we designed the Suit Up Gantry with the robots."

